

The Rise of Tattoo Removal

A multi-source data analysis — May 2026 | v2 (Yelp reviews added)

Executive summary

This analysis combines six independent public data sources to validate the hypothesis that tattoo removal is experiencing sustained, accelerating growth in the United States. Every signal — government establishment counts, search interest, single-chain expansion, Yelp review volume, and social media discussion — points in the same direction.

Key findings

- **+80% establishment growth** in NAICS 812199 from 17,697 in 2012 to 31,863 in 2023, per US Census Bureau County Business Patterns.
- **Search interest doubled** — Google Trends index for "tattoo removal" rose from ~26 in 2004 to 68.8 in 2026, with a step-change in 2021 that has not reversed.
- **LaserAway opened 35 locations in 2024 alone**, growing from 1 in 2006 to 224 by 2026 — a textbook PE-backed expansion curve.
- **181,112 workers employed** in NAICS 812199 as of 2024, up 56% from 115,837 in 2020.
- **77,322 Yelp reviews** across 1,394 businesses dating back to 2006. Volume peaked in 2018–2019, dipped in COVID 2020, rebounded 2021–2023. 78% are 5-star.
- **Reddit discussion exploding** — posts grew from under 50/year pre-2024 to 910 in 2025 and 1,416 in 2026.

Data summary

Metric	Value	Source
NAICS 812199 establishments (2023)	31,863	Census CBP
Growth in establishments (2012→2023)	+80%	Census CBP
BLS establishments (2024)	31,986	BLS QCEW
BLS employment (2024)	181,112	BLS QCEW
Google Trends peak ("tattoo removal")	68.8	Google Trends
LaserAway total locations (2026)	224	LaserAway API
LaserAway locations opened in 2024	35	LaserAway API
Yelp listings (12 cities)	1,394	Yelp Fusion API
Yelp reviews (2006–2026)	77,322	Yelp GraphQL
Yelp 5-star share	78%	Yelp GraphQL

Rows highlighted in green are new in v2. NAICS 812199 covers "Other Personal Care Services" which includes tattoo removal alongside electrolysis and ear piercing.

Source 1: Census Bureau County Business Patterns (NAICS 812199)

Official Census Bureau establishment counts for NAICS 812199 — "Other Personal Care Services" — the official classification for tattoo removal clinics. Most defensible signal in the dataset.

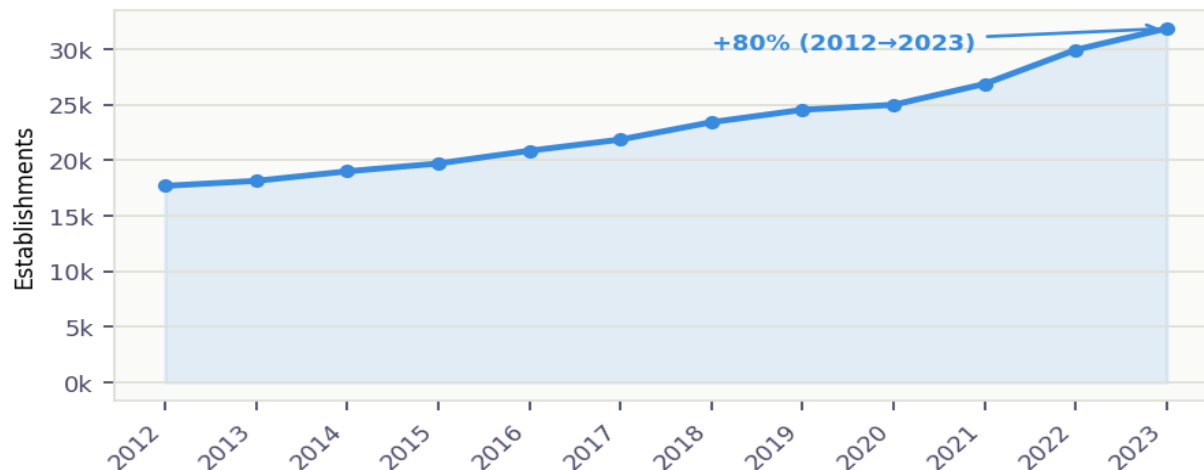


Figure 1. US Census CBP: annual establishment count for NAICS 812199, 2012–2023.

Source 2: Google Trends — search intent

Search volume for "tattoo removal" has risen steadily since 2004 with a sharp spike in 2021 coinciding with post-pandemic pent-up demand. The 2026 index of 68.8 is the highest in the 22-year dataset.

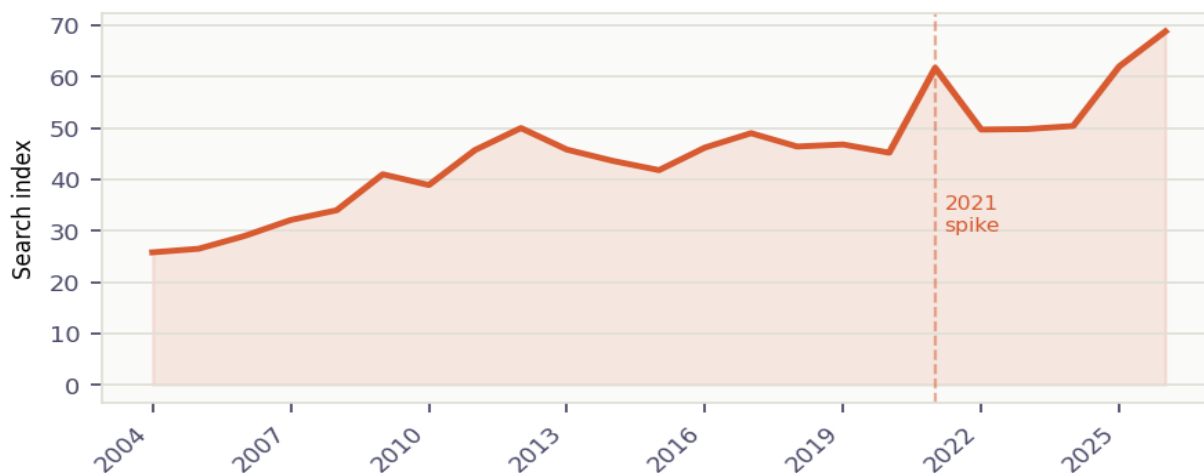


Figure 2. Google Trends monthly search index for "tattoo removal", 2004–2026.

Source 3: LaserAway chain expansion

LaserAway location-level open_date data provides a clean proxy for institutional capital commitment to the sector. Exponential acceleration post-2020 reflects PE investment and a market land-grab.

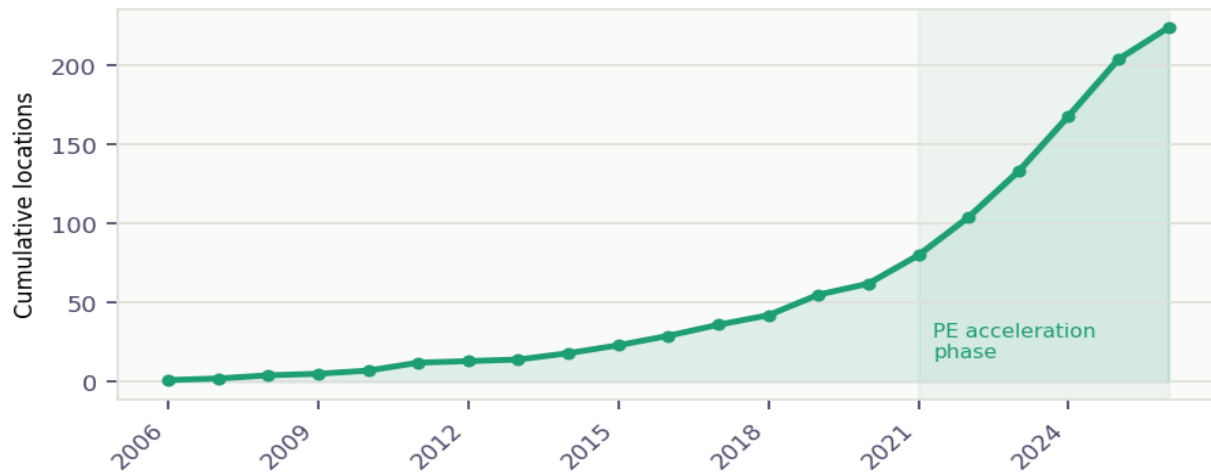


Figure 3. LaserAway cumulative locations opened, 2006–2026. Source: laseraway.com locations API.

Source 4: BLS QCEW — employment & establishments

Both establishment and employment counts show consistent year-over-year growth 2020–2024, with employment growing faster — suggesting existing clinics are adding staff, not just new clinics opening.

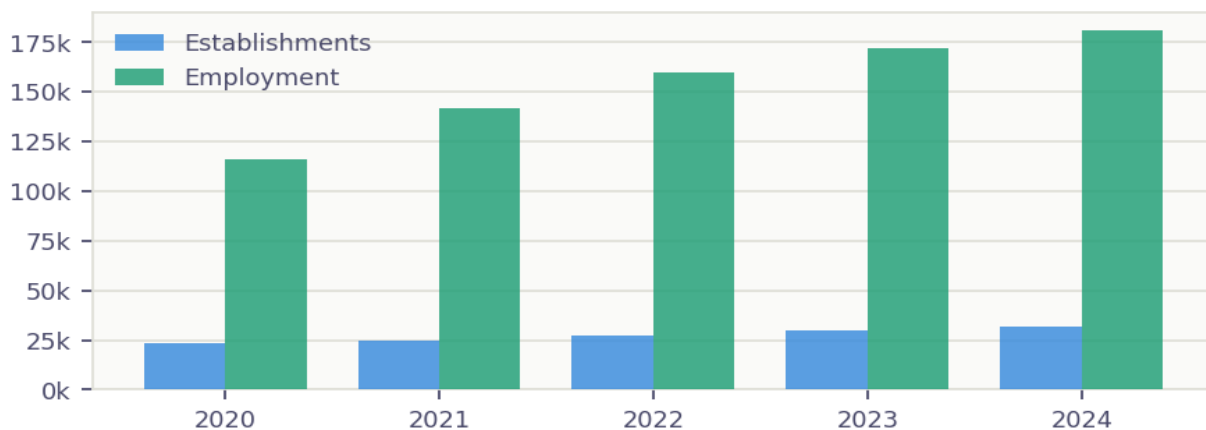


Figure 4. BLS QCEW national annual averages for NAICS 812199, 2020–2024.

Source 5: Yelp reviews — demand proxy ★ NEW in v2

77,322 reviews scraped across 1,394 tattoo removal businesses in 12 US cities, dating back to 2006. Review volume is a direct proxy for customer activity. Volume peaked in 2018–2019, dipped in COVID 2020, and rebounded strongly 2021–2023. The high 5-star share shows service quality has remained consistently high despite rapid industry growth.

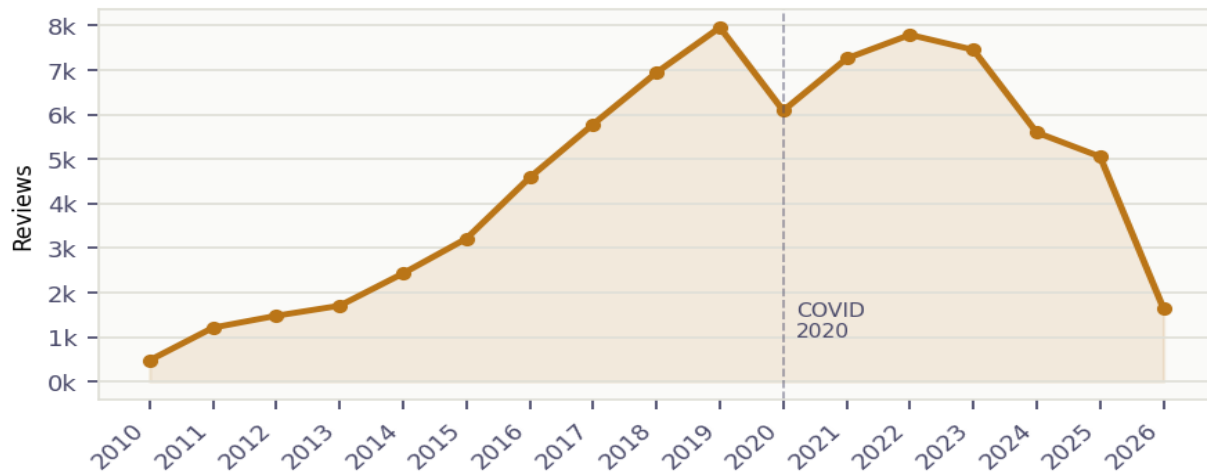


Figure 5. Yelp review volume by year across 1,394 tattoo removal businesses, 2010–2026.

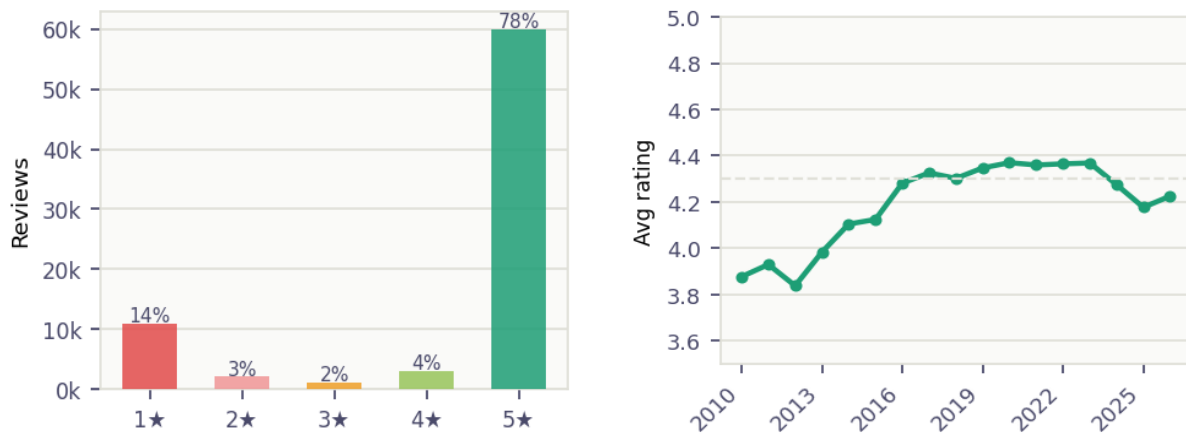


Figure 6. Left: rating distribution across all 77,322 reviews. Right: average rating by year — consistently above 4.2 since 2014.

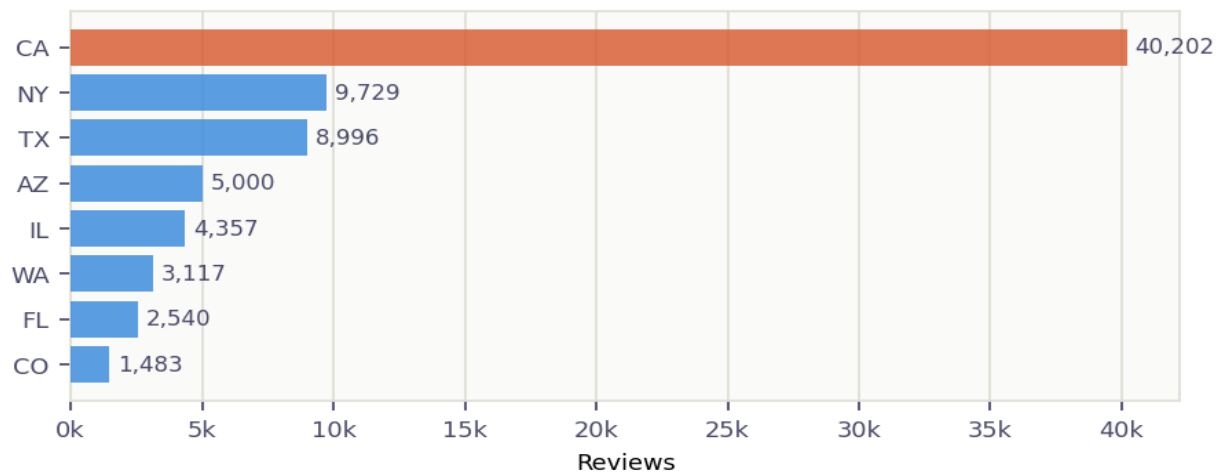


Figure 7. Yelp review volume by state (top 8). CA dominates with 40k+ reviews, driven by LaserAway's West Coast concentration.

Source 6: Reddit discussion volume

Posts across r/tattooremoval, r/tattoos, r/tattoo advice, and r/tifu show near-silence pre-2024 then an explosion in 2025–2026, reflecting genuine community growth around tattoo regret and removal journeys.

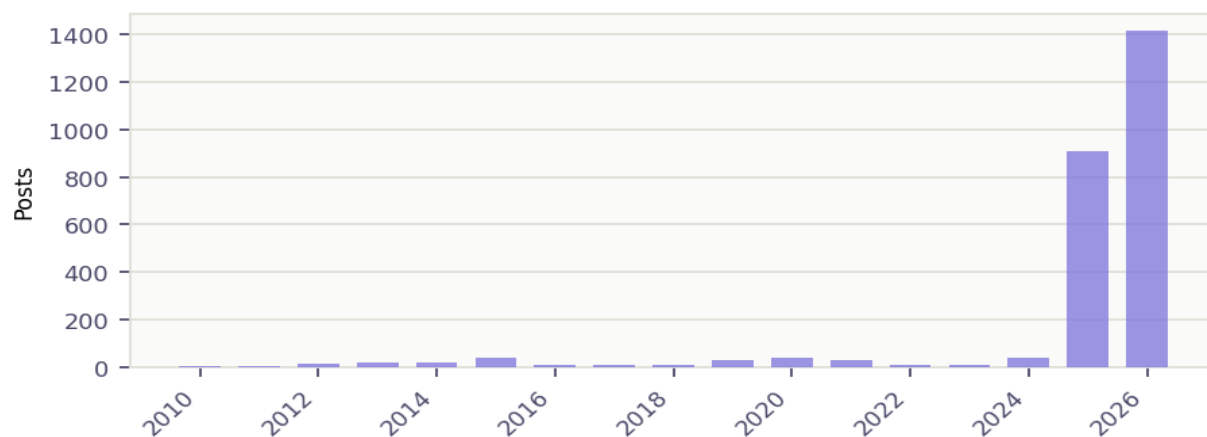


Figure 8. Reddit post volume across 4 subreddits related to tattoo removal/regret, 2010–2026.

Limitations & next steps

NAICS caveat: NAICS 812199 bundles tattoo removal with electrolysis and ear piercing. Yelp business-level data provides a cleaner tattoo-removal-specific signal.

Yelp recency bias: Older businesses may have older reviews underrepresented. The 2024–2026 dip likely reflects data collection timing rather than a real decline.

Geographic coverage: Yelp data covers 12 cities only. A full national picture would require broader city coverage.

Sentiment analysis: The 77k review texts could be analyzed for regret language and treatment journey descriptions — a natural next step.

Report v2 generated May 2026. Sources: US Census Bureau CBP, BLS QCEW, Google Trends, LaserAway Locations API, Yelp Fusion API + GraphQL, Reddit PRAW. Analysis by Zack Burnside.